Middle Miocene magnetostratigraphy of the Pebas Formation at Tamshiyacu and Santa Carina (Iquitos, Peru): a C5AAr (∼13.2–13.4 Ma) tie for the Pan-Amazonian wetland and its *Purussaurus* record

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Abstract

The middle Miocene Pebas Formation records the Pan-Amazonian "mega-wetland," and its lignite beds yield abundant vertebrate fossils — yet the timing and tempo of that record remain poorly constrained, with age uncertainties of a million years or more, because the strata are rarely tied directly to the geomagnetic polarity time scale (GPTS). We present paleomagnetic u-channel records from two cutbank sections ∼170 km apart near Iquitos, Peru — Tamshiyacu (TAM) and Santa Carina (SC), the localities of Gingras et al. (2002) — each preserving a single, well-resolved polarity reversal. Reconstruction of core azimuth recovers geographic declination, so the reversal is expressed antipodally in both inclination and declination. Tied by the reversal, both sections share a normal-to-reversed transition — the C5ABn–C5AAr boundary — whereas their lignite flooding surfaces do not align and are demonstrably diachronous. Four independent constraints — the polarity pattern, a palynological floor (>12.7 Ma), a *Purussaurus* ceiling (<13.8 Ma), and U-Pb detrital-zircon ages from the *Purussaurus neivensis*–bearing La Venta section (youngest zircon populations ∼13.9 Ma; Mora-Rojas et al., 2023) — converge on **chron C5AAr, ∼13.2–13.4 Ma**. A *Purussaurus* cranial horizon discovered at Tamshiyacu in 2025 falls within C5AAr, dating it to a ∼180 kyr window (∼13.2 Ma) — ∼1 Myr older than the dated *P. neivensis* horizon at La Venta (the Monkey Beds, chron C5An.1n, ≤12.17 Ma) — a sub-million-year calibration that extends the dated record of the genus in the Pan-Amazonian wetland and is relevant to evolutionary and biogeographic models. Down-core X-ray fluorescence shows iron is dominantly authigenic, recording reducing, episodically brackish bottom water; net accumulation is very low (∼3 m/Myr), marking a condensed, incomplete succession. These records provide the first direct GPTS calibration of the Pebas at Iquitos and a chronologic bridge to the La Venta fauna.

INTRODUCTION

The Miocene reorganization of northern South America — Andean uplift, the Pebas mega-wetland, and the eventual birth of the transcontinental Amazon — is central to Neotropical biogeography (Hoorn et al., 2010a; Wesselingh & Salo, 2006). The formation's lignites and shell beds yield an abundant vertebrate fauna — crocodylians, turtles, rodents, and the giant caiman *Purussaurus* — recovered almost yearly from actively eroding cutbanks; the Iquitos Pebas alone has produced a hyperdiverse crocodylian community, including the ∼13 Ma gavialoid *Gryposuchus pachakamue* whose skull records parallel evolution in the proto-Amazonian mega-wetland (Salas-Gismondi et al., 2015, 2016). Yet individual fossil horizons typically carry age uncertainties of a million years or more, because the age framework of the Pebas Formation rests largely on molluscan and palynological biostratigraphy and sparse radiometric ages and its strata are seldom tied directly to the GPTS. Such coarse control limits the fauna's use in the evolutionary and biogeographic models that increasingly demand sub-million-year resolution to test rates of diversification, dispersal, and body-size evolution. Whether Pebas deposition was lacustrine and essentially freshwater (Wesselingh & Salo, 2006) or tidally influenced and periodically brackish-marine (Räsänen et al., 1995; Gingras et al.,

2002) has been debated for decades, and the correlation of scattered outcrops to one another and to dated faunas such as La Venta remains loose.

Here we calibrate two Pebas sections near Iquitos, Peru, to the GPTS using paleomagnetic u-channel data, and integrate the result with sedimentology, ichnology (after Gingras et al., 2002), down-core geochemistry, and vertebrate and U-Pb age control. The sections are the same cutbanks — Tamshiyacu and Santa Julia II (here "Santa Carina") — whose ichnology first argued for tidal influence (Gingras et al., 2002), allowing our magnetostratigraphy to be read directly against an established facies and process model.

GEOLOGIC SETTING AND METHODS

The Pebas Formation (≈Solimões Fm. of Brazil) accumulated in the Andean foreland/back-arc of western Amazonia during the middle Miocene, as a low-gradient system of shallow lakes, swamps, and floodplains periodically connected to the sea (Hoorn, 1993; Hoorn et al., 2010a,b). At Tamshiyacu (4.01°S, 73.15°W) and Santa Carina (3.36°S, 71.79°W; Fig. 1) the formation comprises blue-grey laminated and massive muds (facies F1A/F1B of Gingras et al., 2002), heterolithic silty sands (F2A–F2D), rooted lignites (F3A), winnowed mollusc shell beds (F3B), and *Glossifungites*-demarcated firmgrounds (F3C), organized into lignite-capped parasequences.

Oriented u-channels were sampled from continuous mud-dominated intervals and measured at Oregon State University. Characteristic remanent magnetization (ChRM) was isolated from despiked, high-coercivity (30–70 mT) steps by principal-component analysis — the upper bound chosen to exclude a high-field gyroremanence (GRM) contribution (see *Magnetic mineralogy*); at ∼4°S the geocentric axial dipole field is shallow, so normal polarity corresponds to negative inclination. Because the u-channels were azimuthally unoriented, polarity is determined from *inclination sign alone*, which is independent of declination; declinations are treated as relative only, and the reversal is expressed as coupled inclination and ∼180° declination changes (a qualitative reversal test). Bed-by-bed lithologic logs were rendered with `pystrat`; parasequences, grading, ichnology and physical structures are transferred from the logs of Gingras et al. (2002) (Tamshiyacu parasequences TmA–TmB; Santa Carina = their Santa Julia II, SJA–SJC) by tying their metres to ours at the shared lignite-capped flooding surfaces. The La Venta comparison uses the composite standard section of Mora-Rojas et al. (2023) (bed-by-bed lithofacies, their supplement s6) and their reinterpretation of the Flynn et al. (1997) polarity sequence (supplement s15), with reversals tied to the ATNTS2012 (Hilgen et al., 2012). Down-core geochemistry was measured by energy-dispersive X-ray fluorescence (XRF) core scanning.

RESULTS

Polarity records. Each section preserves shallow, dual-polarity ChRM directions and a single robust reversal. Tamshiyacu is normal-below, reversed-above; Santa Carina is normal–reversed–normal. At each reversal the inclination changes sign in step with a ∼180° swing in relative declination (a positive reversal test), consistent with a primary (detrital to early-diagenetic) remanence. At Tamshiyacu the uppermost core group (the *Purussaurus*-bearing lignite and capping beds) is NRM-only with poor susceptibility and yields no interpretable direction; usable polarity is therefore restricted to the lower ∼2.5 m, and the upper ∼1.2 m is shown as no data, although XRF was scanned over the full ∼3.8 m (Fig. 2).

Shared reversal. Hung on the reversal, both sections show the same normal-to-reversed transition at the datum — the C5ABn–C5AAr boundary — with Santa Carina continuing up into the succeeding normal chron (C5AAn) and Tamshiyacu truncated within C5AAr (Fig. 2). The lignite flooding surfaces do not coincide once the reversals are matched, demonstrating that they are diachronous facies boundaries.

Facies and parasequences. Both sections resolve into the lignite-capped, coarsening-upward bay-margin parasequences of Gingras et al. (2002), each founded on a *Glossifungites* (*Thalassinoides*) firmground (Fig. 2). Tamshiyacu spans TmA — laminated mud coarsening into sand–mud interbeds, capped by a hummocky, storm-emplaced sand that fines upward into bioturbated silty sand and a laterally continuous ironstone-nodule horizon — and the base of TmB, whose basal lignite yields the *Purussaurus* cranial horizon beneath a winnowed shell bed. Santa Carina spans the top of SJA, the mud-dominated SJB (starved ripples, shell lenses, a silty coarsening-upward top) and the base of SJC. Tamshiyacu is mud- and silt-dominated (86% of the section; no clean sand, no carbonate concretions), whereas Santa Carina is coarser and more fossiliferous (a metre-scale sand body, additional shell beds, and carbonate concretions), consistent with a more basinward bay-centre and a more marginal bay-margin position, respectively, on a low-gradient shoreline.

Geochemistry. XRF shows that total Fe does not track magnetic-mineral concentration (magnetic susceptibility) but instead co-varies with S and Ca+Sr: iron is dominantly authigenic, held in pyrite and carbonate (Fig. 2). Discrete S–Fe–Ca-enriched intervals mark reducing, shell-bearing horizons; intervening beds are more oxidized and detritally-diluted.

Magnetic mineralogy. Alternating-field demagnetization removes the remanence by $\sim$100 mT (a ferrimagnetic carrier), but the coercivity behaviour varies down-section: most Santa Carina intervals are soft (median destructive field, MDF, $\sim$10–35 mT; magnetite), whereas Tamshiyacu Group 3 and the uppermost Santa Carina core are hard (MDF $\geq$70 mT) and show a diagnostic intensity *increase* above $\sim$70 mT — gyroremanent magnetization (GRM) characteristic of the iron sulfide *greigite*, consistent with the authigenic, S-bearing pyritic facies (Fig. 3). We therefore fit the ChRM below the GRM onset (30–70 mT). Critically, the polarity zonation is essentially unchanged by this choice: recomputed from the GRM-excluded fit, the Santa Carina reversed zone and its bounding N$\rightarrow$R reversal — the datum correlated to C5AAr — move by $\leq$1 cm, and only the finer sub-structure at Tamshiyacu is GRM-sensitive. The remanence is thus detrital-to-early-diagenetic (greigite forms during early sulfate reduction, at or near deposition), and the C5AAr correlation is robust to the magnetic carrier.

DISCUSSION

Age. Four independent constraints converge on chron C5AAr, $\sim$13.2–13.4 Ma: (i) the shared reversal and the N–R–N thickness pattern; (ii) a palynological floor (zones T-15/T-16, $>$12.7 Ma; Jaramillo et al., 2011); (iii) a *Purussaurus* maximum-age ceiling ($<$13.8 Ma); and (iv), most decisively, U-Pb detrital-zircon geochronology of the *Purussaurus neivensis*–bearing La Venta section (Honda Group), whose fossil-rich upper La Victoria Formation yields youngest zircon populations of $\sim$13.9 Ma (sample 44011, YSP 13.9$\pm$0.3 Ma) and whose C5AAr interval there spans 13.18–13.36 Ma (Mora-Rojas et al., 2023) — an anchor external to the Pebas. The Tamshiyacu *Purussaurus* cranial horizon lies at 2.71 m, in the TmB basal lignite $\sim$0.17 m above the top of the measured C5AAr record, and is therefore bracketed by C5AAr–C5AAn. At La Venta the dated *P. neivensis* horizon, the Monkey Beds (stratigraphic level 9, $\sim$557–566 m in the composite section), lies $\sim$13 m above the base of C5An.1n in the reinterpreted polarity column and at $\sim$12.0–12.2 Ma in the U-Pb age model (Mora-Rojas et al., 2023) — $\sim$1 Myr younger than Tamshiyacu (Fig. 2). The Iquitos cranial therefore does not share the La Venta chron; it places *Purussaurus* in the Pan-Amazonian wetland $\sim$1 Myr before its best-dated Laventan occurrence, linking the Iquitos Pebas to the older, upper La Victoria part of the Laventan succession rather than to the Monkey Beds. Propagating the U-Pb-calibrated La Venta age model through this magnetostratigraphic tie (Monte Carlo; the model sampled at the correlative La Venta level — the C5AAr top, 176.6 m in the composite section, $-20/+15$ m — and intersected with the chron bracket) yields an inferred age for the Tamshiyacu *Purussaurus* of 13.18 Ma (95% CI 13.04–13.35 Ma). Notably, the La Venta age model alone is broad at this level ($\sim$13.1 Ma, 95% CI 12.8–13.5 Ma);

the sub-million-year precision derives from the C5AAr–C5AAn magnetostratigraphic bracket, i.e. from the paleomagnetic correlation rather than the U-Pb dates in isolation. The tie is independently consistent with molluscan biostratigraphy: the hyperdiverse Iquitos crocodylian assemblage, including *Gryposuchus pachakamue*, is assigned to Mollusc Zone 8 (∼13 Ma) in the same sections (Salas-Gismondi et al., 2016), and our C5AAr calibration now places that assemblage on the GPTS to ∼180 kyr.

Environment. The authigenic Fe–S–Ca geochemistry records a reducing, sporadically dysaerobic bottom water in which bacterial sulphate reduction pyritized the mud; because sulphate is scarce in freshwater, the punctuated pyrite enrichments most plausibly track brief brackish incursions, and the Ca+Sr shell beds are their winnowed transgressive lags. This independently supports the tidally-influenced, brackish bay-margin interpretation from ichnology and tidal rhythmites at the same localities (Gingras et al., 2002; Räsänen et al., 1995), superimposed on a dominantly freshwater mega-wetland (Hoorn et al., 2010a; Wesselingh & Salo, 2006).

Condensation and correlation. Net accumulation is very low: the C5AAr chron (∼180 kyr) is expressed in only ∼0.5 m at Santa Carina (∼3 m/Myr compacted; ∼6–9 m/Myr decompacted). This is an order of magnitude below the ∼100 m/Myr implied by orbital (obliquity) cyclicity elsewhere in the Pebas (Hoorn et al., 2022) and the ∼45–130 m/Myr regional average from the formation's ∼350–1000 m thickness (Hoorn et al., 2010a). The discrepancy is diagnostic of *incompleteness*: at a sediment-starved, low-accommodation bay margin (Gingras et al., 2002), rapid intra-cycle deposition was repeatedly interrupted by non-deposition, transgressive erosion (the *Glossifungites* firmgrounds), and winnowing (shell lags), so net accumulation is slow. The same low-accommodation architecture makes lignite flooding surfaces diachronous and explains why the two sections correlate only loosely by lithology; the reversal provides the isochronous tie (Fig. 2), and its offset from the lignite ties quantifies the diachroneity. The regional correlation to the U-Pb-dated La Venta composite section, where C5AAr occupies 153.5–176.6 m, reinforces the C5AAr tie (Fig. 2).

The low accumulation rate is not anomalous (Fig. 4). Across the C5AA interval the Iquitos margin (∼3 m/Myr compacted, ∼6–9 decompacted) matches the starved open-marine record at ODP Site 1237 (Nazca Ridge; ∼7.7 m/Myr; Mix et al., 2003), yet is an order of magnitude below the astronomically tuned Ceara Rise carbonates downstream in the equatorial Atlantic (∼16 m/Myr, ODP Site 926; Backman & Raffi, 1997) and the Pebas basin-scale average (∼45–130 m/Myr; Hoorn et al., 2010a, 2022). A starved, low-accommodation bay margin at ∼13 Ma is therefore expected, and the condensation is a depositional signal, not a correlation artifact.

CONCLUSIONS

Paleomagnetic records from Tamshiyacu and Santa Carina provide the first direct GPTS calibration of the Pebas Formation at Iquitos. Both sections share the C5ABn–C5AAr reversal, and four independent constraints place the studied interval in chron C5AAr, ∼13.2–13.4 Ma. A *Purussaurus* cranial horizon at Tamshiyacu lies within C5AAr, ∼1 Myr older than the U-Pb-dated La Venta occurrence of *P. neivensis* in the Monkey Beds (C5An.1n). Authigenic Fe–S–Ca geochemistry confirms reducing, episodically brackish conditions consistent with a tidally-influenced bay margin, and very low net accumulation (∼3 m/Myr) identifies the record as condensed and incomplete — the expected signature of a low-accommodation Pan-Amazonian wetland margin. More broadly, by pinning a single fossil horizon to a ∼180 kyr polarity chron and placing it against the U-Pb-dated La Venta section, the approach converts an abundant but coarsely dated fauna into a sub-million-year chronologic framework — resolution suitable for calibrating Neotropical evolutionary and biogeographic models, and a template for dating the many other fossiliferous Pebas cutbanks that at present lack direct GPTS control.

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

[Funding; field and laboratory assistance; OSU paleomagnetism facility; *Purussaurus* identification (Antoine, pers. comm.).]

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FIGURE CAPTIONS

Figure 1. Location of the Tamshiyacu (TAM) and Santa Carina (SC) sections along the Amazon River near Iquitos, Peru, with the regional Miocene localities La Venta and Contamana and the approximate extent of the Pebas mega-wetland. Political boundaries and river courses schematic; site markers at true coordinates.

Figure 2. Master magnetostratigraphic correlation. *Left* — the Tamshiyacu (TAM) and Santa Carina (SC) sections, each with lithology (`pystrat` grain-size widths and FGDC swatches; facies after Gingras et al., 2002); a feature lane with grading triangles (fining-/coarsening-upward), *Glossifungites* firmgrounds, bioturbation, root traces, hummocky cross-stratification, ripples, molluscs and concretions (after Gingras et al., 2002 and our field logs); parasequence brackets (TmA–TmB, SJA–SJC) with their basal surfaces (dashed); raw and 7-cm-median ChRM inclination; polarity (hatched = no data, including the NRM-only upper TAM core); and cleaned log-ratio XRF (ln[Fe/coh], ln[S/coh]) over the full scanned interval, all hung on the shared C5AAr reversal (red band, spanning each site's reversed interval). The Tamshiyacu *Purussaurus* (purple) carries its inferred age; the posterior is inset beneath TAM. *Right* — the La Venta composite section (Honda Group; 0–625 m, lithofacies and structures digitised from Mora-Rojas et al., 2023), with the Monkey Beds (StL 9; La Venta *P. neivensis*, dark red) and Fish Bed (StL 11) marked, and its reinterpreted polarity column; the GPTS (ATNTS2012; Hilgen et al., 2012); and the La Venta detrital-zircon U-Pb Bayesian age model (95% CI, labelled with sample height). Shaded ribbons tie C5AAr from Peru to La Venta to the GPTS; dashed lines tie every La Venta reversal to its GPTS boundary (solid dark red: base of C5An.1n, 12.17 Ma, 13 m below the Monkey Beds). Mollusc Zone 8 ($\sim$13 Ma) is shown for regional context.

Figure 3. Rock magnetism and remanence carrier. *(a)* Median AF coercivity spectra (intensity/NRM vs. peak field) by core group: most Santa Carina intervals are soft (magnetite), whereas Tamshiyacu Group 3 and the uppermost Santa Carina core are hard and show a high-field intensity *increase* above $\sim$70 mT — gyroremanent magnetization (GRM) diagnostic of the iron sulfide greigite. *(b)* ChRM inclination refit excluding the GRM-affected steps (30–70 mT) versus the full 30–100 mT fit: polarity is unchanged for 89% of specimens and the reversal zonation is robust, so the C5AAr tie does not depend on the magnetic carrier.

Figure 4. Middle-Miocene accumulation. *(a)* Age–depth across the C5AA interval (all pinned at the C5AAr base): the Iquitos margin (this study, $\sim$7 m/Myr decompacted) tracks the starved open-marine reference ODP Site 1237 (Nazca Ridge; Mix et al., 2003) and is much slower than the astronomically tuned Ceara Rise carbonate record (ODP Site 926, equatorial Atlantic; Backman & Raffi, 1997). *(b)* Accumulation-rate context on a log scale: the Iquitos site ($\sim$3 m/Myr compacted, 6–9 decompacted) is an order of magnitude below the Pebas basin-scale average ($\sim$45–130 m/Myr; Hoorn et al., 2010a) and the orbital estimate ($\sim$100 m/Myr; Hoorn et al., 2022), identifying it as a genuinely starved sub-environment rather than a miscorrelation artifact.

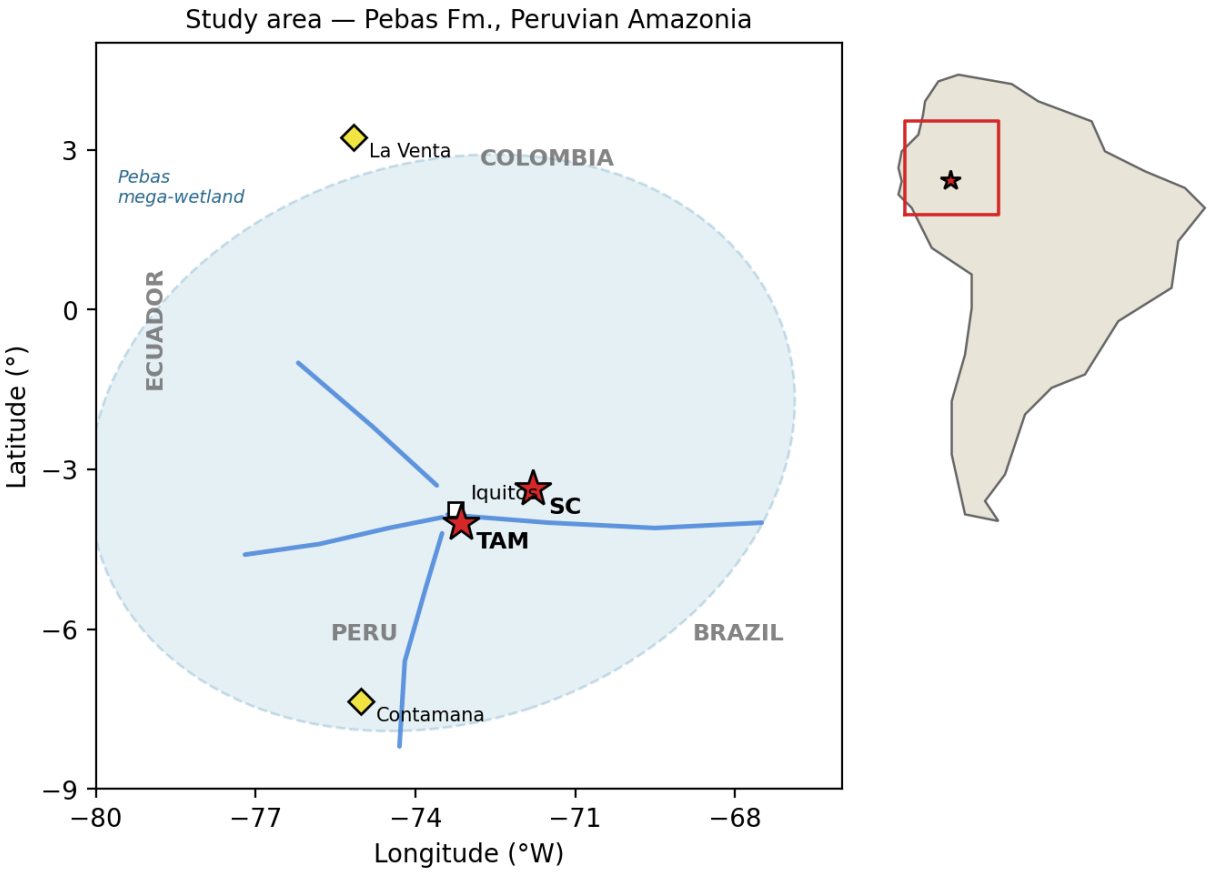
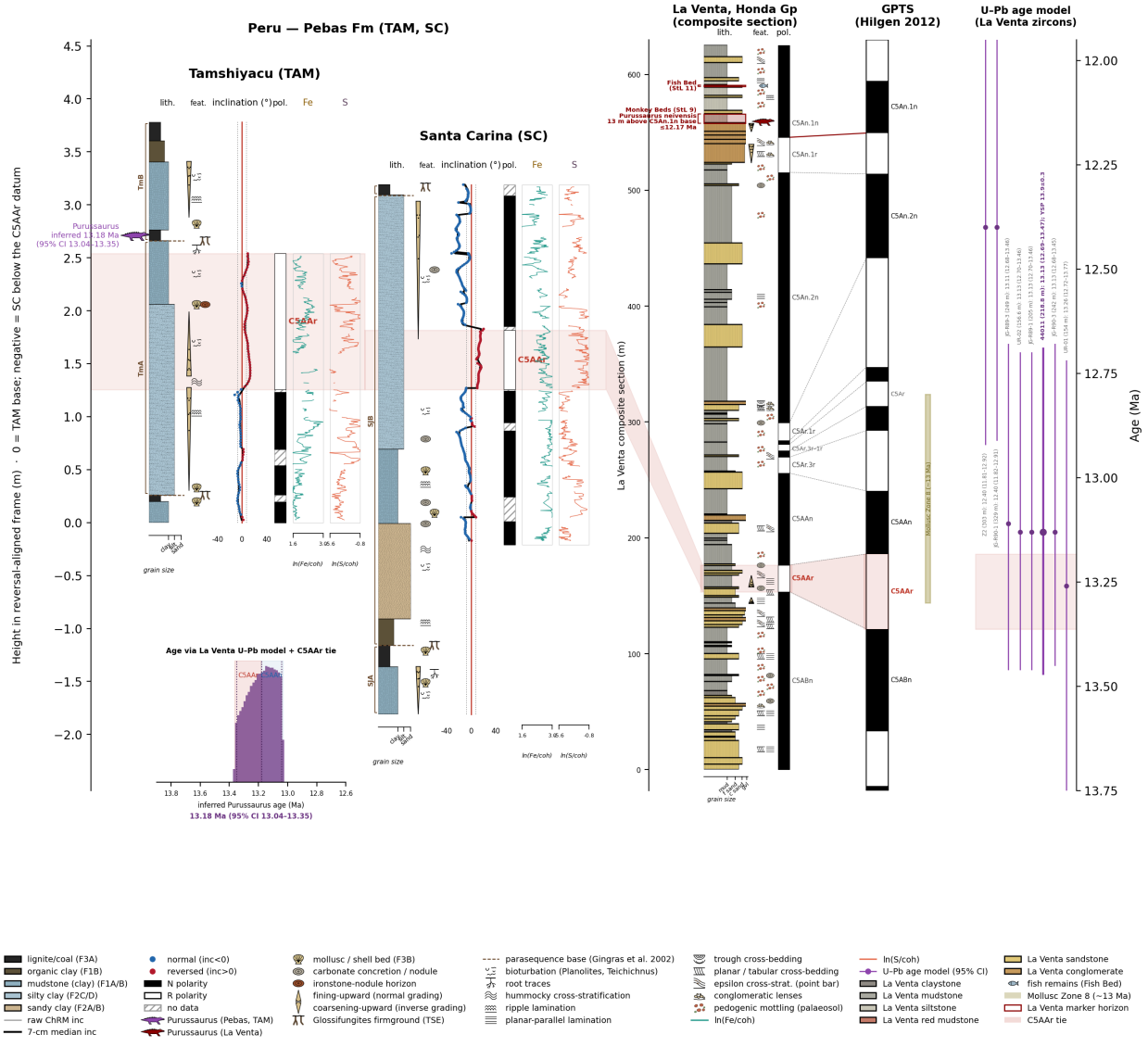
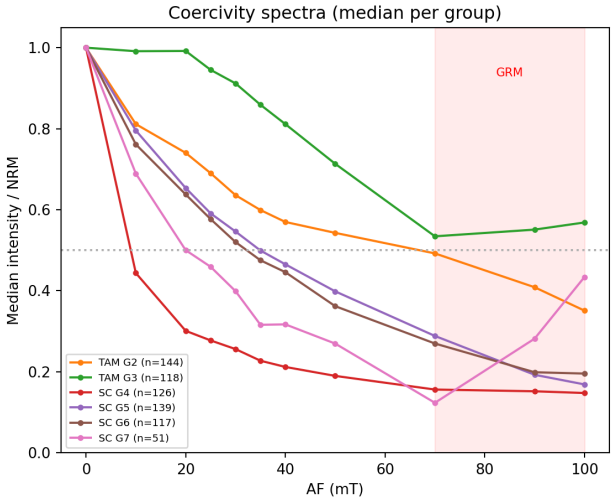
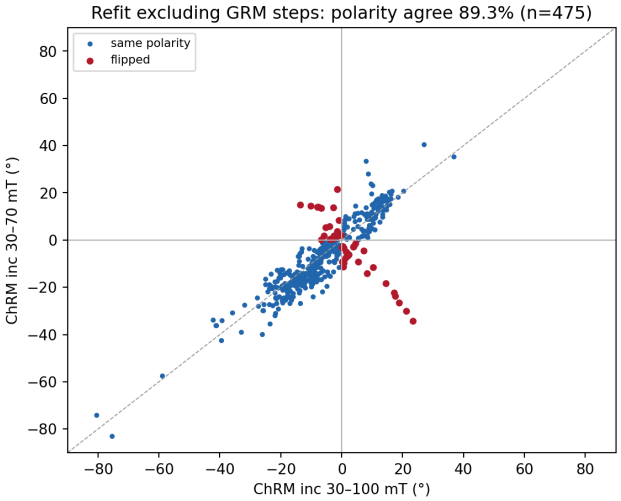

Study area — Pebas Fm., Peruvian Amazonia
La Venta
COLOMBIA
Pebas
mega-wetland
ECUADOR
Iquitos
SC
TAM
PERU
BRAZIL
Contamana
3
0
−3
−6
−9
−80
−77
−74
−71
−68
Latitude (°)
Longitude (°W)

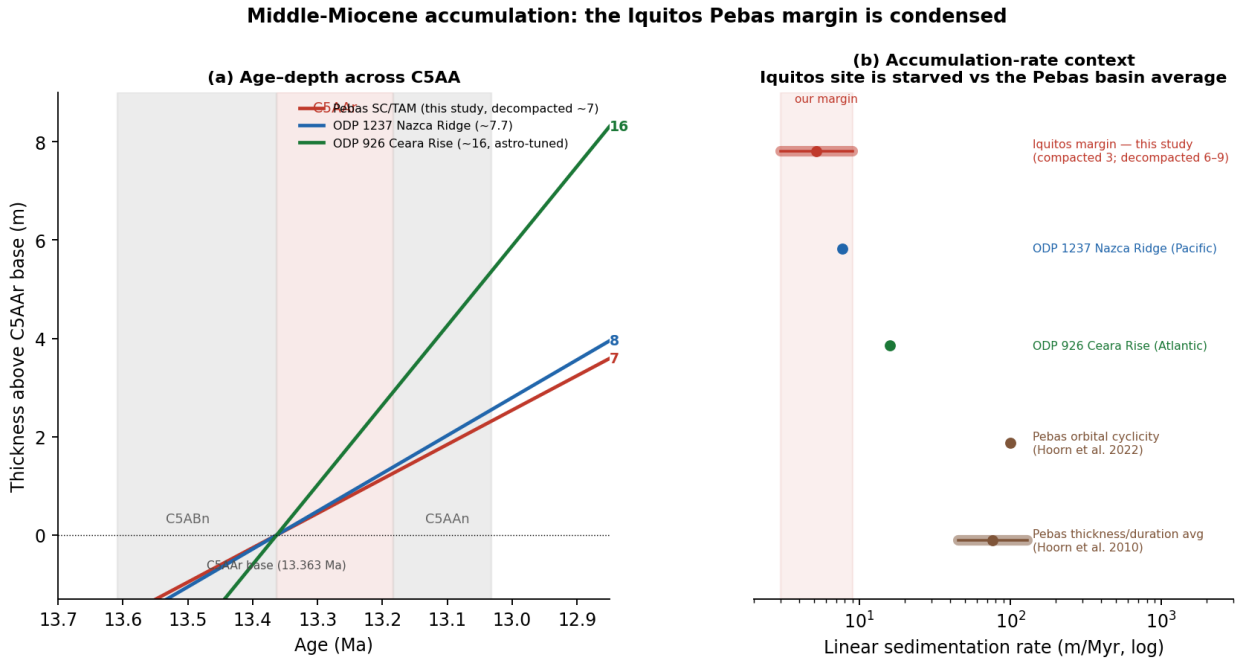
Figure 2. Pebas magnetostratigraphy (TAM, SC) correlated to the U–Pb-calibrated La Venta composite section and the GPTS



Lithology after pystrat (grain-size widths + FGDC swatches); TAM & SC parasequences, grading, ichnology & physical structures after Gingras et al. 2002 (Tamshiyacu TmA/TmB; Santa Carina = their Santa Julia SJA-SJC; tied on the lignite-capped flooding surfaces); La Venta composite section (lithology, lithofacies codes, grading) digitised from Mora-Rojas et al. 2023 suppl. s6, polarity from their s15 reinterpretation of Flynn et al. 1997, reversals tied to Hilgen et al. 2012; Peru columns aligned on the shared C5AAr reversal; XRF cleaned (cps≥80k, MSE≤3.5, gaps unbridged, 3-pt median) and shown as log-ratios to coherent scatter (Weltje & Tjallingii 2008); Monkey Beds (StL 9) & Fish Bed (StL 11) from Mora-Rojas et al. 2023 (suppl. s6, s10) with U–Pb Bayesian age model (detrital zircons, 95% CI); La Venta Purussaurus (P. neivensis, Monkey Beds) after Carrillo et al. 2023; Mollusc Zone 8 after Wesselingh et al. 2006 & Salas-Gismondi et al. 2016. DRAFT.


Coercivity spectra (median per group)
Median intensity / NRM
AF (mT)
GRM
TAM G2 (n=144)
TAM G3 (n=118)
SC G4 (n=126)
SC G5 (n=139)
SC G6 (n=117)
SC G7 (n=51)


Refit excluding GRM steps: polarity agree 89.3% (n=475)
same polarity
flipped
ChRM inc 30–70 mT (°)
ChRM inc 30–100 mT (°)


Middle-Miocene accumulation: the Iquitos Pebas margin is condensed
(a) Age–depth across C5AA
Pebas SC/TAM (this study, decompacted ~7)
ODP 1237 Nazca Ridge (~7.7)
ODP 926 Ceara Rise (~16, astro-tuned)
16
8
7
C5ABn
C5AAn
C5AAr base (13.363 Ma)
Thickness above C5AAr base (m)
Age (Ma)
(b) Accumulation-rate context
Iquitos site is starved vs the Pebas basin average
our margin
Iquitos margin — this study
(compacted 3; decompacted 6–9)
ODP 1237 Nazca Ridge (Pacific)
ODP 926 Ceara Rise (Atlantic)
Pebas orbital cyclicity
(Hoorn et al. 2022)
Pebas thickness/duration avg
(Hoorn et al. 2010)
Linear sedimentation rate (m/Myr, log)